

Low Income Household Water Assistance Program

FLORIDA LIHWAP PROFILE SUMMARY



The Florida Department of Economic Opportunity (DEO) Low Income Household Water Assistance Program (LIHWAP) is funded at \$75.7 million in FY21. The state of Florida prioritized low-income households with disconnection of drinking and wastewater utilities. Once services for those households were restored, Florida engaged water utilities to direct funding toward low-income households that had past due accounts to pay arrearage amounts stated on the household bill in addition to the flat benefit amount indicated by the household size and income. DEO gathered information on disconnections and arrearages by surveying water and wastewater utility providers prior to the implementation of the program. This information also directed the focus of their outreach efforts with stakeholders, and it was used to determine funding award amounts distributed to Florida LIHWAP subrecipient agencies.

Program Operation

The Florida LIHWAP program, which began in January 2022, is managed at the state level in partnership with 30 local service providers consisting of Community Action Agencies, local, city, and county governments, and other non-profits. LIHWAP is administered by local service providers that currently administer Florida's LIHEAP.

Florida's LIHWAP prioritizes relief assistance in the following order to **three priority groups**:

- Customers whose water and/or wastewater services have been disconnected
- Customers facing the threat of disconnection of their water or wastewater services
- Customers in need of rate reduction in payments for current water and wastewater services

FY21 LIHWAP FUNDING ALLOCATION



AMOUNT

TOTAL: \$75,756,689

- ARP: \$33,285,013
- CAA: \$42,471,676



OPERATIONAL PRIORITIES

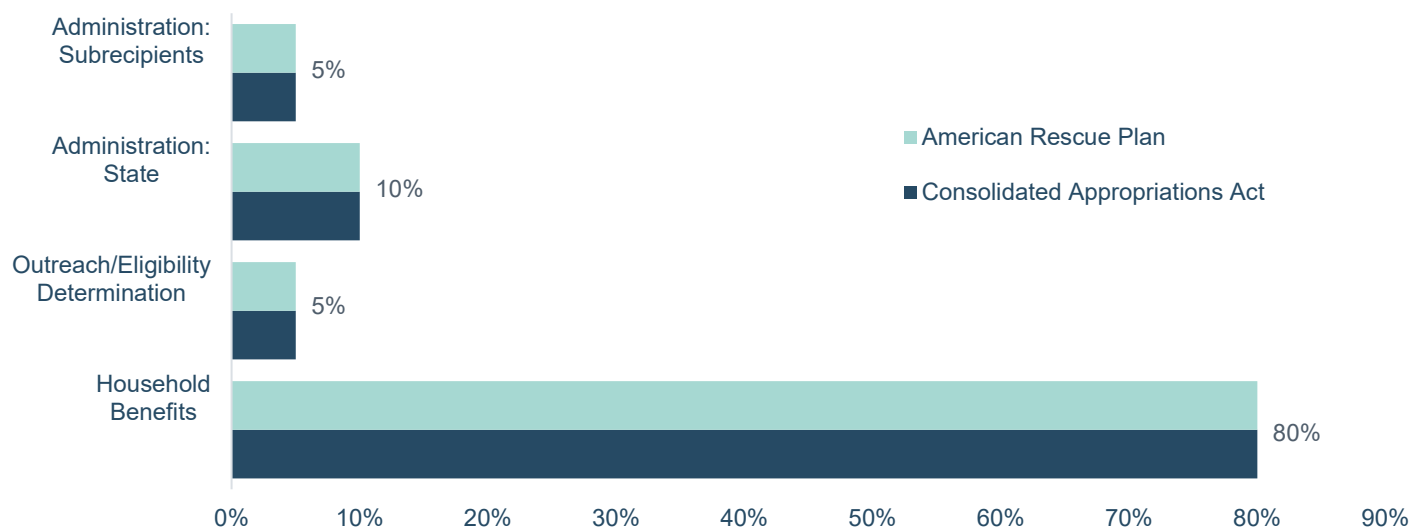
- Restoration of services
- Prevention of disconnection
- Reduction in arrearages



PROGRAM COORDINATION

- Joint application for LIHEAP, CSBG, WAP, and LIHWAP
- Intake referrals to/from other programs
- One-stop intake centers

Use of Funding by Funding Source



Benefits on Behalf of Households

Under Florida's administration of the program, eligible households may receive up to \$1,000 in benefits. Applicants with one or more elderly members, with one or more disabled members, or with one or more young children (5 years of age or under) receive an additional benefit. Agency staff use household income, size, and drinking water and wastewater burden to determine benefit levels.

Priority Populations

Households that meet program eligibility criteria and fall in one of the following categories will receive an additional award benefit.

- ✓ People with disabilities
- ✓ Families with young children
- ✓ Older Adult/Seniors (60+)

Priority is also given to clients with high water burdens and those requiring restoration, prevention of disconnection, and reducing rate charges.

Program Outreach Activities

- Place posters/flyers in local and county social service offices, offices of aging, Social Security offices, Veterans Affairs, etc.
- Publication of articles or public service announcements in local newspapers or broadcast media announcements.
- Work directly with water utilities to identify potential recipients.
- Inclusion of inserts in water vendor billings to inform individuals of the availability of LIHWAP assistance.
- Mass mailing(s) to prior-year LIHEAP recipients or recipients of other government benefits
- Automated phone campaigns and/or social media outreach.
- Multi-lingual announcements in languages spoken by low-income households within utility service area and/or notification in ethnic language news and broadcast media outlets
- Inform low-income applicants of the availability of all types of LIHWAP assistance at application intake for other low-income programs.
- Outreach to faith-based institutions, including those serving low-income people and people of color.
- Information posted to DEO's website.

Eligibility and Benefit Determination Criteria

Title	Item
Income Threshold	
	150% Federal Poverty Guideline
	60% State Median Income
✓	Hybrid Federal and State (based on household size)
	- 60% SMI (households with up to 8 members) - 150% FPL (households with 9 or more members)
Categorical Eligibility	
✓	LIHEAP
	Means-tested Veterans Programs
✓	Supplemental Nutritional Assistance Program (SNAP)
✓	Supplemental Security Income (SSI)
✓	Temporary Assistance for Needy Families (TANF)
Eligible Households	
✓	Homeowners
✓	Renters
Benefit Level Determination*	
✓	Income
✓	Household size
✓	Household drinking water burden
✓	Household wastewater burden
Benefit Amount	
\$1	Minimum
\$1000	Maximum
Benefit Period	
	One Time
✓	Multiple

* Grant recipients are required to determine a benefit level for households seeking assistance with their current water and wastewater bills. Benefit level determination is based on household income, size, and drinking water and wastewater burden.

For more information about the Florida LIHWAP, contact:

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